Who Speaks for the Animals?

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(Adapted by ReadWorks)



It seemed like just another hot summer day in New York City. The beaches were crowded with families. The subways were air-conditioned and gave people relief from the heat. That night, they also gave some people a surprise. Just after midnight a woman got on a subway train and noticed a strange smell. She looked around the train and saw something lying on the floor under a row of seats.

"I board a car that's not terribly full," she recalls, sharing her story with the news website *Gothamist*. "And as soon as I enter, a stench hits my nose. It's not the typical…urine/trash smell...it's…fishy? I look down to the end of the car to see a dead shark on the floor."

Photos of the shark showed up online. It was gray and about five feet long. People on the train car with it set the shark in different poses. One popular photo showed the shark with a MetroCard on the floor next to it. A MetroCard is a card that lets people enter the subway, so in the photo the shark looked like it had used the card to enter the subway.

Along with the photos came questions about the shark. People online and in the news asked where the shark had come from. How had it gotten onto the subway? How had it died? Nobody who heard about the strange event could answer these questions.

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One question the people in charge of the subway had to answer was what to do with the deceased shark. Luckily, they were able to deal with the dead animal. At a big subway station they ordered everyone to get off the train with the shark on it. That allowed them to handle the situation themselves. They took the shark corpse off the train and disposed of it. (A corpse is a dead body.)

Even though the subway train was again clean and the fishy stench had gone away, people still had questions. They wondered what had happened to the shark and how it got on the subway. Because the shark had gotten so much attention online and in the news, someone was likely to come forward and explain how it had ended up on a subway train.

People had some of their questions answered when a woman recognized the shark in the photos. The shark on the subway was the same shark that she and her kids had seen on a beach in New York City earlier in the day. The shark had washed up on the beach. Her neighbor's daughter had even picked up the corpse for a photo. Photos of the shark held in the air by a brown-haired girl in sunglasses began to appear online. These photos supported the woman's story.

Apparently the shark had washed onto the beach sometime in the afternoon. It was already deceased by then. People at the beach showed a lot of interest in the small shark. They took photos and gathered around it for a time. After a while, someone picked it up and took it to an amusement park next to the beach. That person left it on the ground by a roller coaster. Someone else decided to take the shark home but left it on the subway instead.

This event called attention to a few issues. The issues have to do with the shark and its death, as well as with the way people in cities think about and act toward wild animals. The surprise appearance of a wild animal is an exciting and unusual event in a big city. The desire that people have to take photos of it, play with it, and even bring it home with them is understandable. After all, where else in a city with millions of people could someone have

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similar experiences with a wild animal from the sea? The animals found in aquariums and zoos are protected from visitors. When people go there, they are usually not allowed to handle the animals.

Another issue is the way people treated the deceased shark. The people who played with its corpse showed no concern over the animal's death. "What would you do?" is a question that should be asked here. Most people know not to go near or touch a wild animal, even if it looks friendly. It could have a disease. It could attack, no matter how gentle it seems. Why do people not have a similar attitude toward dead animals? When does it become okay to disturb wild animals? Even the photos of the shark disturbed its death. The shark was taken all over the city instead of being left on the beach near the ocean where it belonged.

What remains unknown is whether people will speak out against the situation. Will anyone speak for the animals?

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